

# ETHNOTE

# Usability Testing

University of Houston UX Lab

May 2025



# OVERVIEW

As part of our research, we conducted usability testing on potential users of Ethnote, a digital fieldnote-taking application. Our goal was to evaluate the app’s ease of use, navigation, and overall user experience. Through direct observation and user feedback, we identified usability challenges that informed our design recommendations.

## METHODOLOGY

### Panel Size

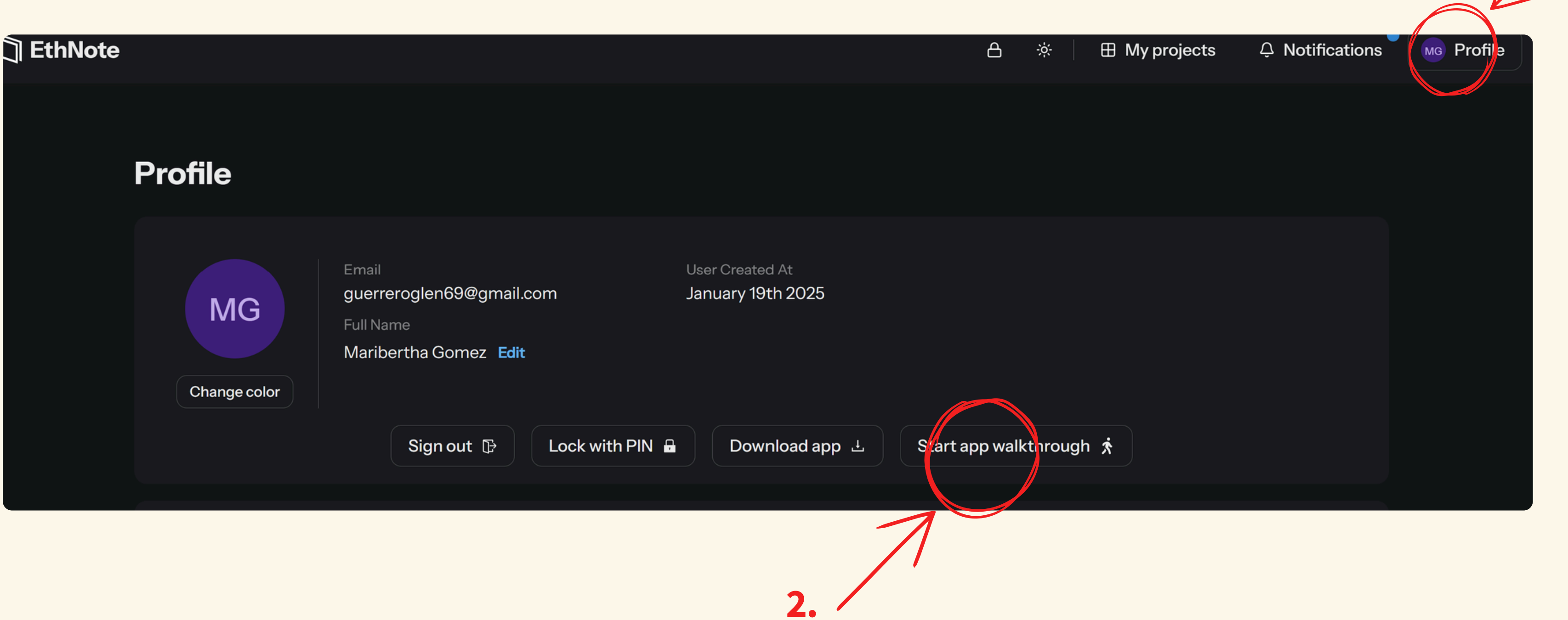
We conducted usability testing with a panel of **7 participants** representing the app’s target users. Participants had **varying levels of experience with digital note-taking tools**, ensuring a diverse range of feedback.

### Testing Procedure

All sessions were **conducted remotely** via online video calls. Participants shared their screens while completing a set of predefined tasks on Ethnote. We observed their interactions in real time, noted points of friction, and followed up with brief interviews to gather additional feedback.

# TASK #1:

Can you locate a walkthrough of the app?



# TASK #1:

Can you locate a walkthrough of the app?

## Solution:

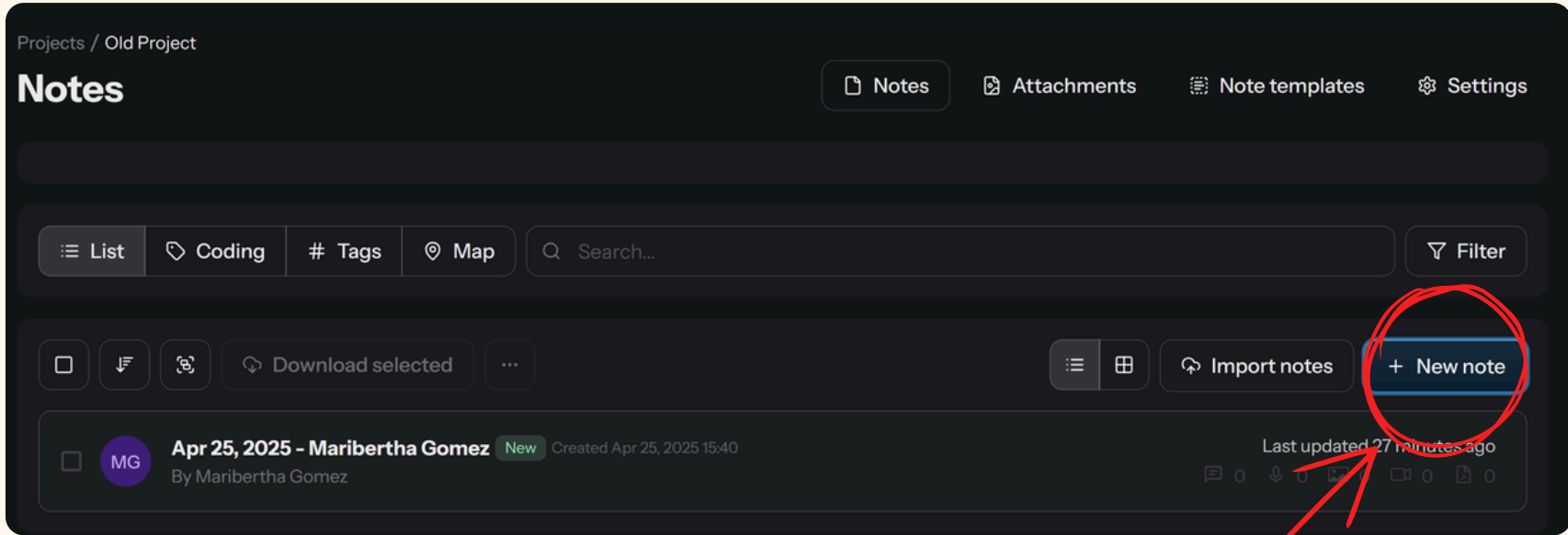
1. Go to the My Projects page
2. Click Profile in the top right
3. Click Start app walkthrough

## Overall Findings:

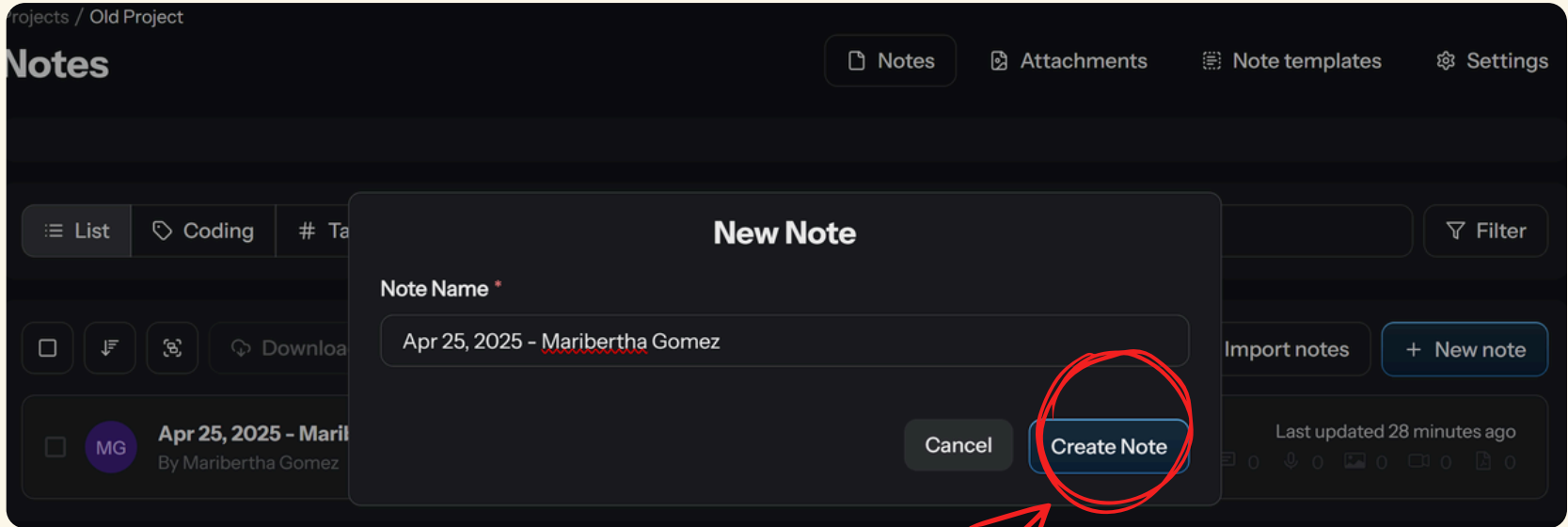
- **Navigation was confusing** for some users, especially locating the walkthrough.
- One tester clicked around (Projects page, logo, New Project) before finding it and rated the experience 1/5 due to the unclear layout.
- The **walkthrough placement** in the profile section felt **unintuitive**; users expected it elsewhere.
- One tester found it intuitive and completed quickly (~10 seconds).
- Another tester struggled, did not complete it initially, but understood once it was explained that it was a tutorial.
- This was identified as **the most difficult step in the overall UX test**.

# TASK #2:

Use Ethnote to create a new note. Enter anything you want for the text. (After they finish) Add an annotation to this note.



1.



2.



# TASK #2:

Use Ethnote to create a new note. Enter anything you want for the text. (After they finish) Add an annotation to this note.

## Solution:

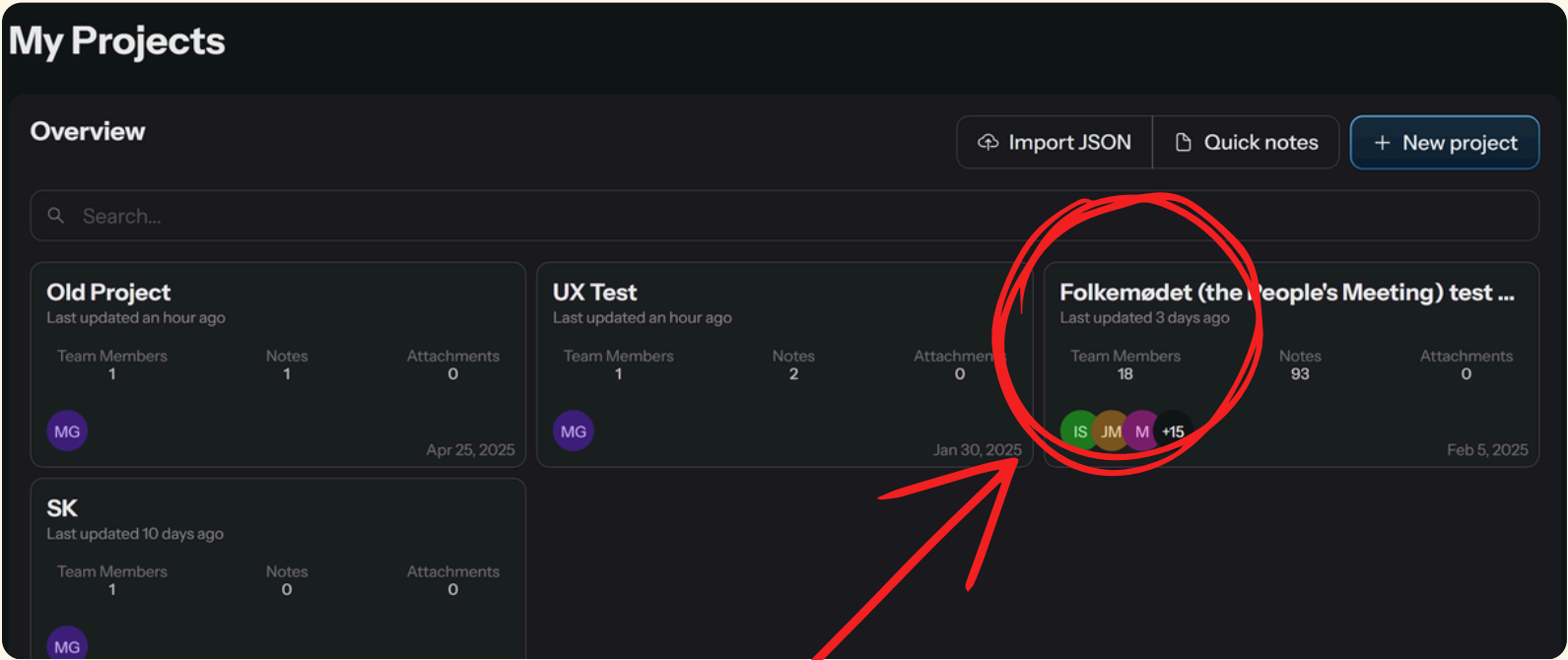
- 1. Click on project
- 2. Click + New Note
- 3. Enter some text in the Text field
- 4. Click the highlighter looking button in the Text area to add an annotation.

## Overall Findings:

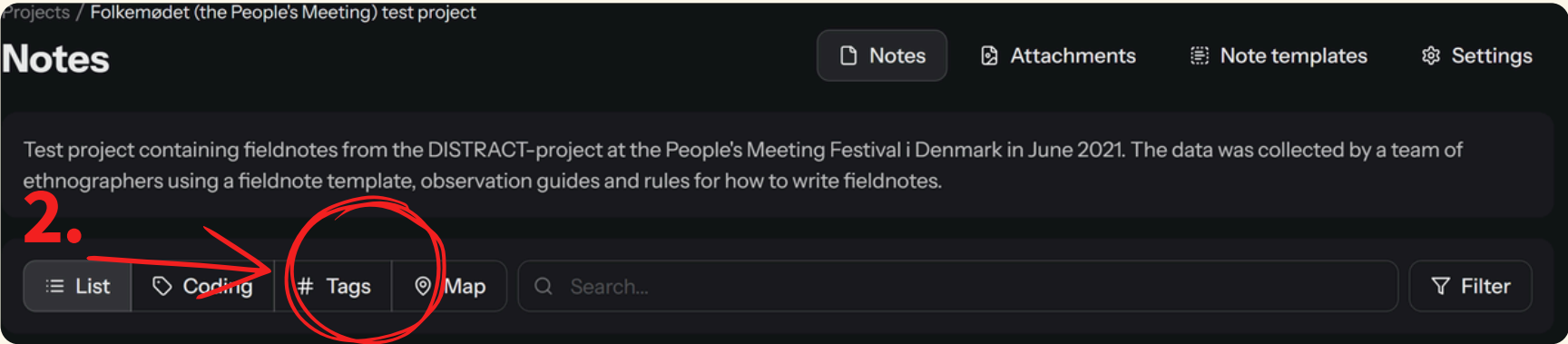
- Users **struggled to locate the annotation text** after entering it.
- Tester couldn't see where the code went after it was entered, causing **confusion about annotation placement**.
- The interface **lacked clear cues** for **saving or confirming notes**.
- **Icons and labels** were **not intuitive** or familiar to users.
- One tester accidentally started a new project but quickly corrected the mistake.
- Once users found the correct steps, task completion was fast (~20 seconds).
- **First impressions** were **confusing**, leading to **lower satisfaction scores**.

# TASK #3:

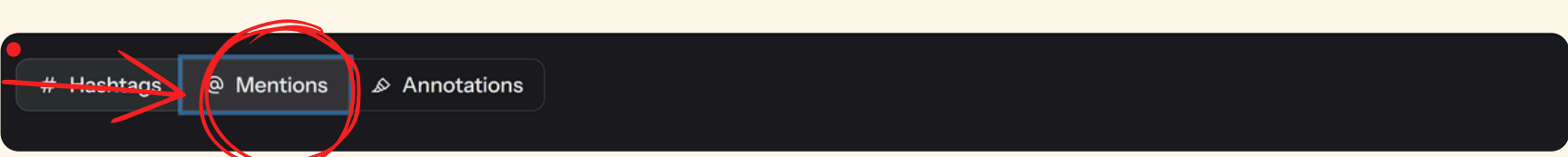
Find all the tags for “Malik” in the “Folkemødet” project.



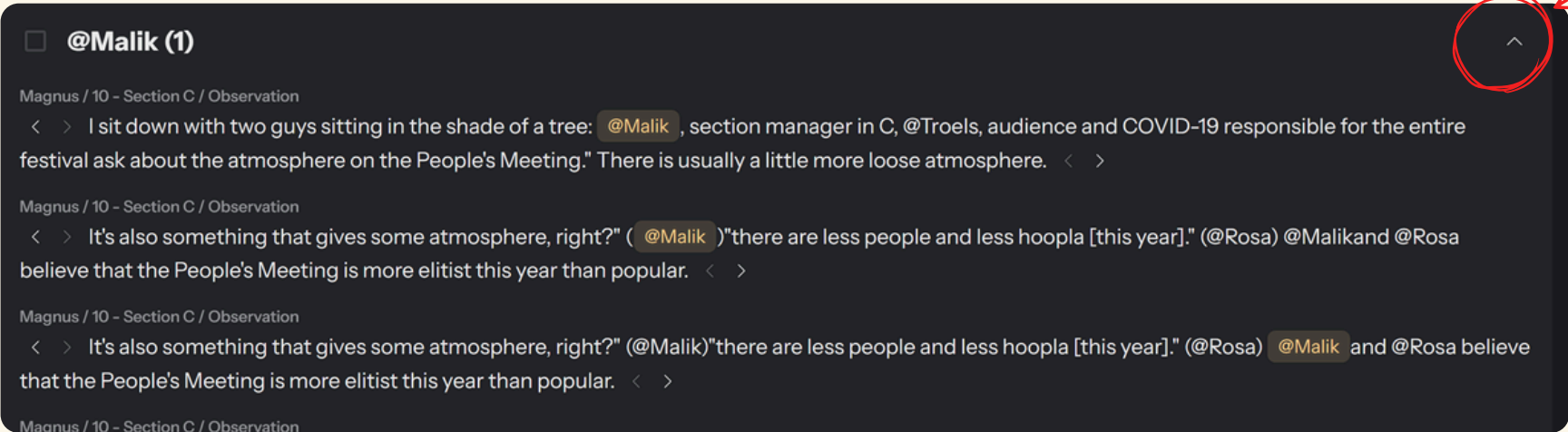
1.



2.



3.



4.

# TASK #3:

Find all the tags for “Malik” in the “Folkemødet” project.

## Solution:

- 1. Enter project “Folkemødet”
- 2. Click on the “Tags” box
- 3. Click on the “mentions” box under the “tags” box
- 4. Scroll down to where all the other names are mentioned and click on the drop-down arrow on the right side of the box. This will show every instance of when @malik is mentioned.

## Overall Findings:

- Testers were **able to locate mentions of @malik, but navigation was initially confusing.**
- One tester found it fairly easy after some exploration, rated the experience 5/7, and noted it would be easier on future attempts.
- **Users experienced confusion between hashtags, the tag icon, and @mentions,** which slowed down task completion.
- **Other names** appearing **in the list** made it **harder to quickly find the desired mention.**
- One tester struggled on step 3, understood the goal but did not complete finding the mention box.
- Task times ranged between 00:51 and 1:19, showing a **moderate learning curve on first use.**



# TASK #4:

Find the notes mentioning “freedom of speech” in the “Folkemødet” project and locate that text in any notes you find.

My Projects

Overview

Import JSON

Quick notes

New project

Search...

Old Project

Last updated 13 days ago

Team Members

1

Notes

1

Attachments

0

MG

Apr 25, 2025

UX Test

Last updated 13 days ago

Team Members

1

Notes

2

Attachments

0

MG

Jan 30, 2025

Folkemødet (the People's Meeting) test ...

Last updated 16 days ago

Team Members

18

Notes

93

Attachments

0

MG

UM

M

+15

Feb 5, 2025

1.

List

Coding

Tags

Map

Search

Filter

2.

M

9 - Parking space at the test center

Created Feb 6, 2025 02:37

By Magnus

Last updated 3 months ago

3.

Text

Observation ^

Man in his 30s.-Listens because they are some pin hats. They have some right points, "but...". Had heard from an acquaintance that they would be here. Am on a long weekend on Bornholm, but went down to see it. MB. Also mentions the other demo against sending Syrians back to Syria, was also part of it. Stopped because of curiosity. Is curious about many things, has also been to church.-What does he think about the location? It is their own fault that they have applied for the location themselves. They probably would have liked to have been closer, but then they should have investigated it better.-What does he think about them being at the People's Festival? They are allowed to do what is freedom of speech. But find it annoying.

4.

# TASK #4:

Find the notes mentioning “freedom of speech” in the “Folkemødet” project and locate that text in any notes you find.

## Solution:

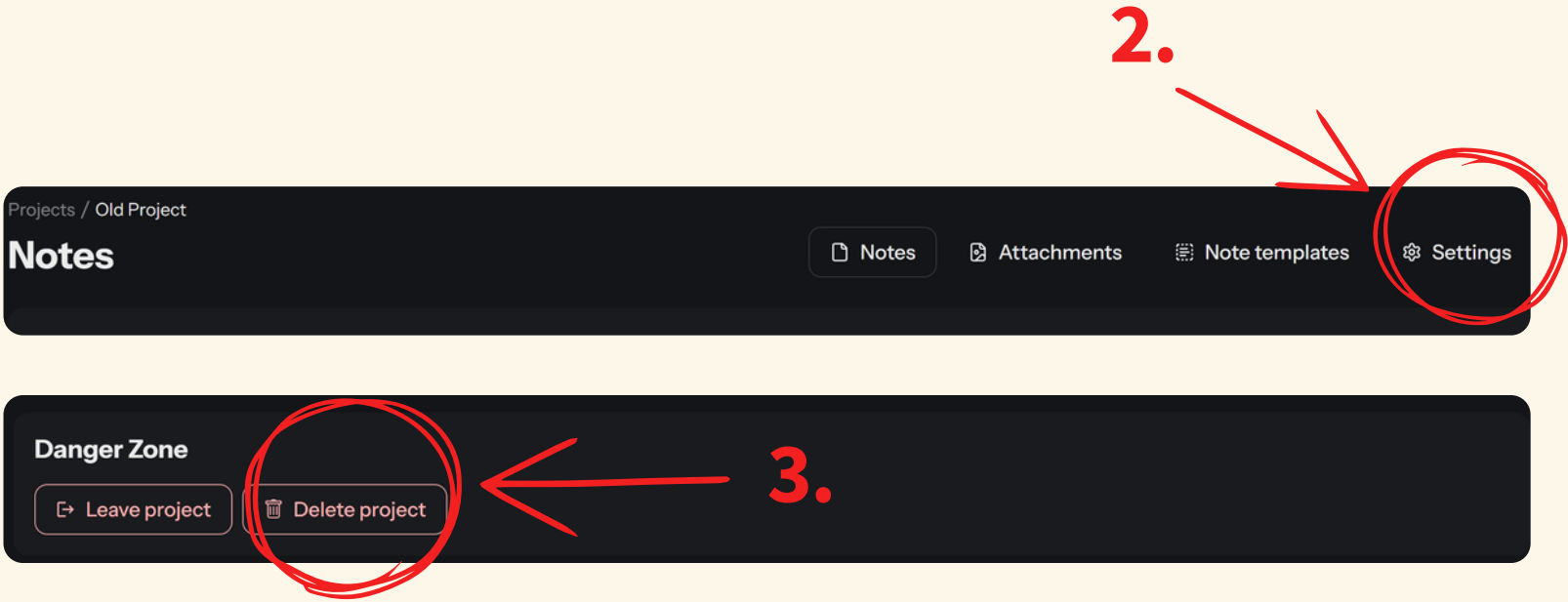
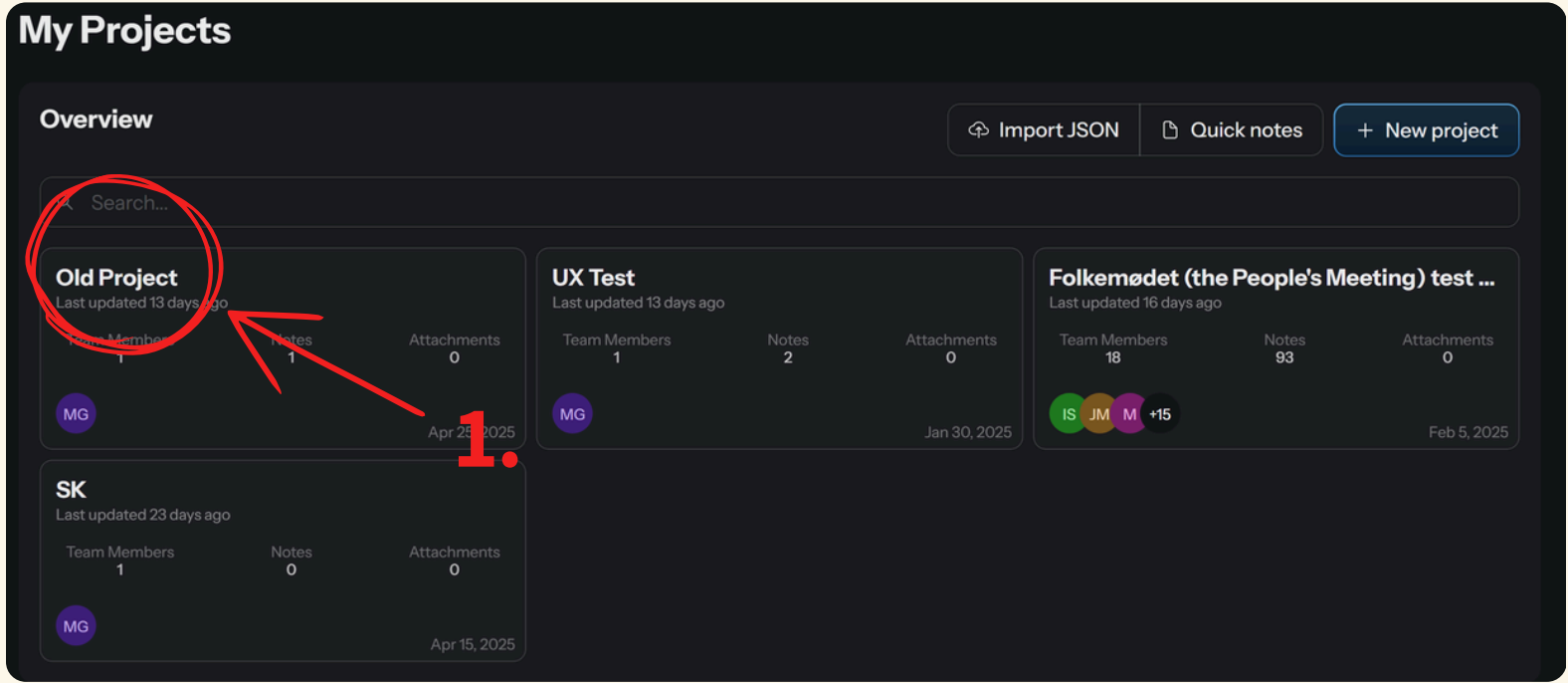
- 1. Enter project “Folkemødet”
- 2. Use search bar next to filter
- 3. Enter “freedom of speech” into search bar
- 4. Enter the note “9 - Parking space at the test center”
- 5. Scroll down into the Text box and locate the sentence, which is the second to last sentence
- 6. Open the note 5-Section D Tent 8 (they will probably run into back button issues).

## Overall Findings:

- Testers **struggled to find the note** "5-Section D Tent 8" due to **confusing navigation and cluttered timestamps**.
- One tester navigated multiple sections (Tags, Mentions, Overview, Comments, Quotes, Lists, Filters, Maps, Coding) but could not easily locate the note and overlooked the search bar initially.
- Rated the experience 2/5, citing that the interface did not offer an intuitive search flow.
- One tester found it very easy (~7 seconds) once noticing the search feature.
- Another tester was unable to complete the task, struggling with similar note names (e.g., "freedom of...") that confused the results.
- **Task times ranged from 7 seconds to 1 minute 40 seconds**, depending on whether the search bar was spotted early.

# TASK #5:

Delete the project “Old Project”.



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Delete the project “Old Project”.

## Solution:

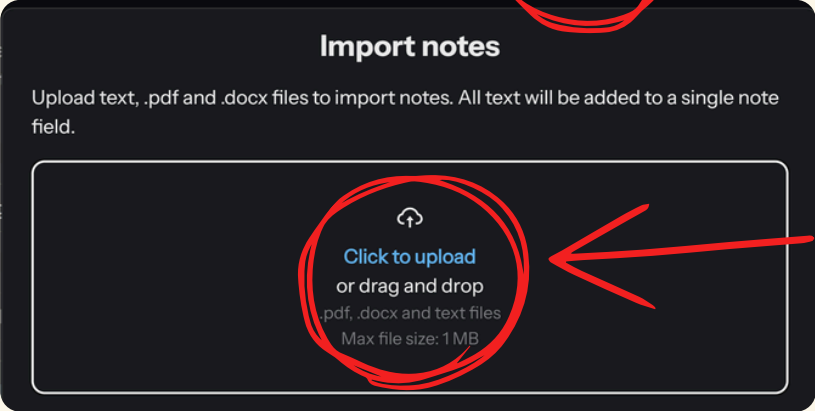
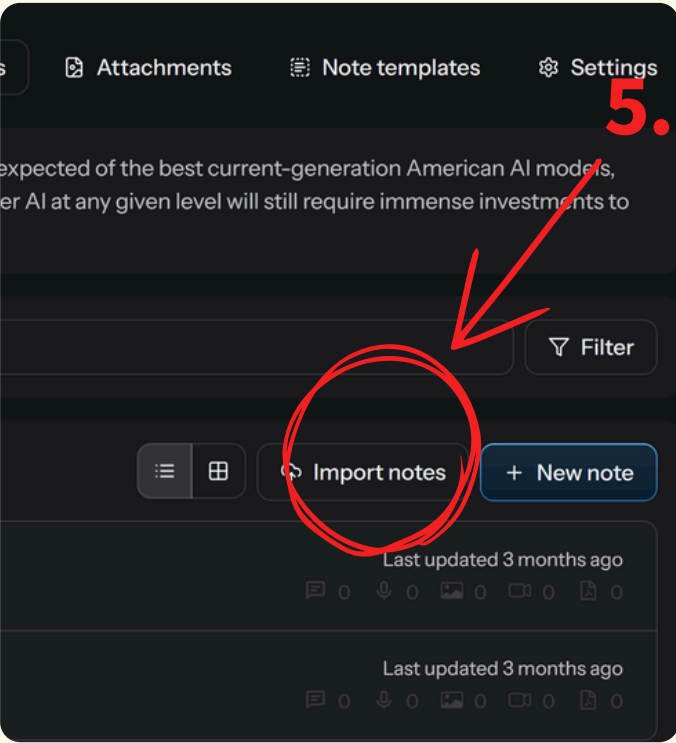
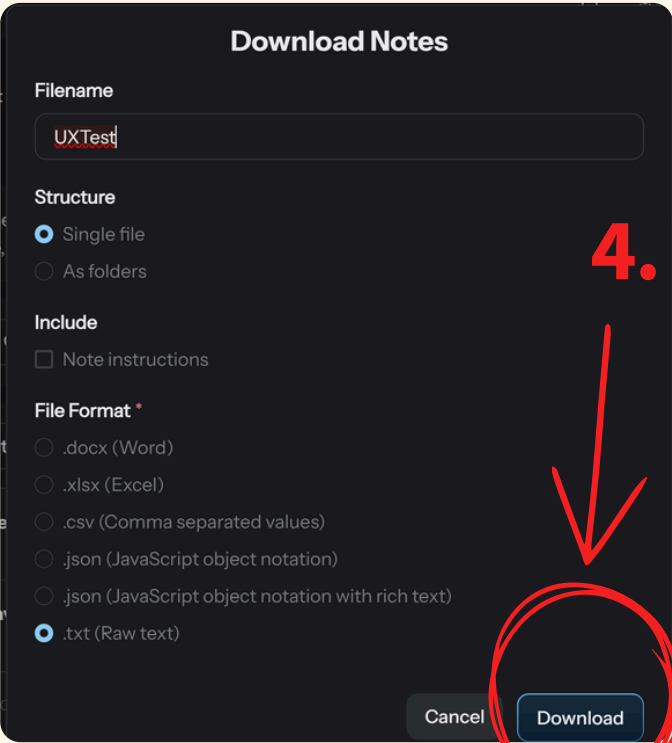
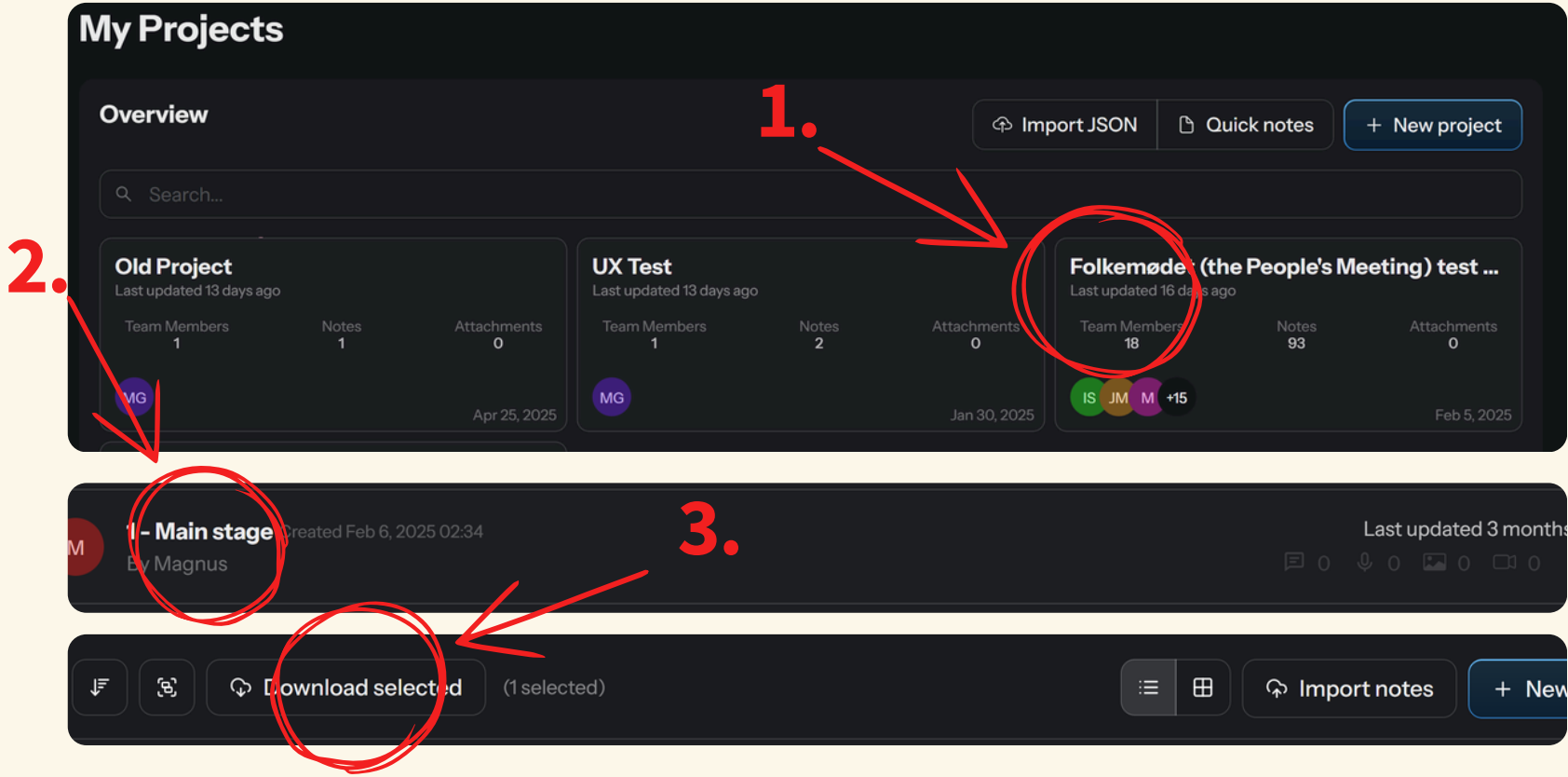
1. Go to home page, where all the projects are
2. Click into the Old Project project
3. Click settings
4. Hit delete project

## Overall Findings:

- Testers had **difficulty locating the "Delete" option** for a project.
- One tester thought the delete action should not be hidden in project settings and suggested a more visible option (e.g., an ellipsis menu on each project card).
- She needed guidance to find the correct path and rated the experience 5/7, mentioning the current placement felt unintuitive.
- **Time to complete varied**

# TASK #6:

Show me how you would move one of the “Main Stage” notes from the “Folkemødet” project into a new project.





# TASK #6:

Show me how you would move one of the “Main Stage” notes from the “Folkemødet” project into a new project.

## Solution:

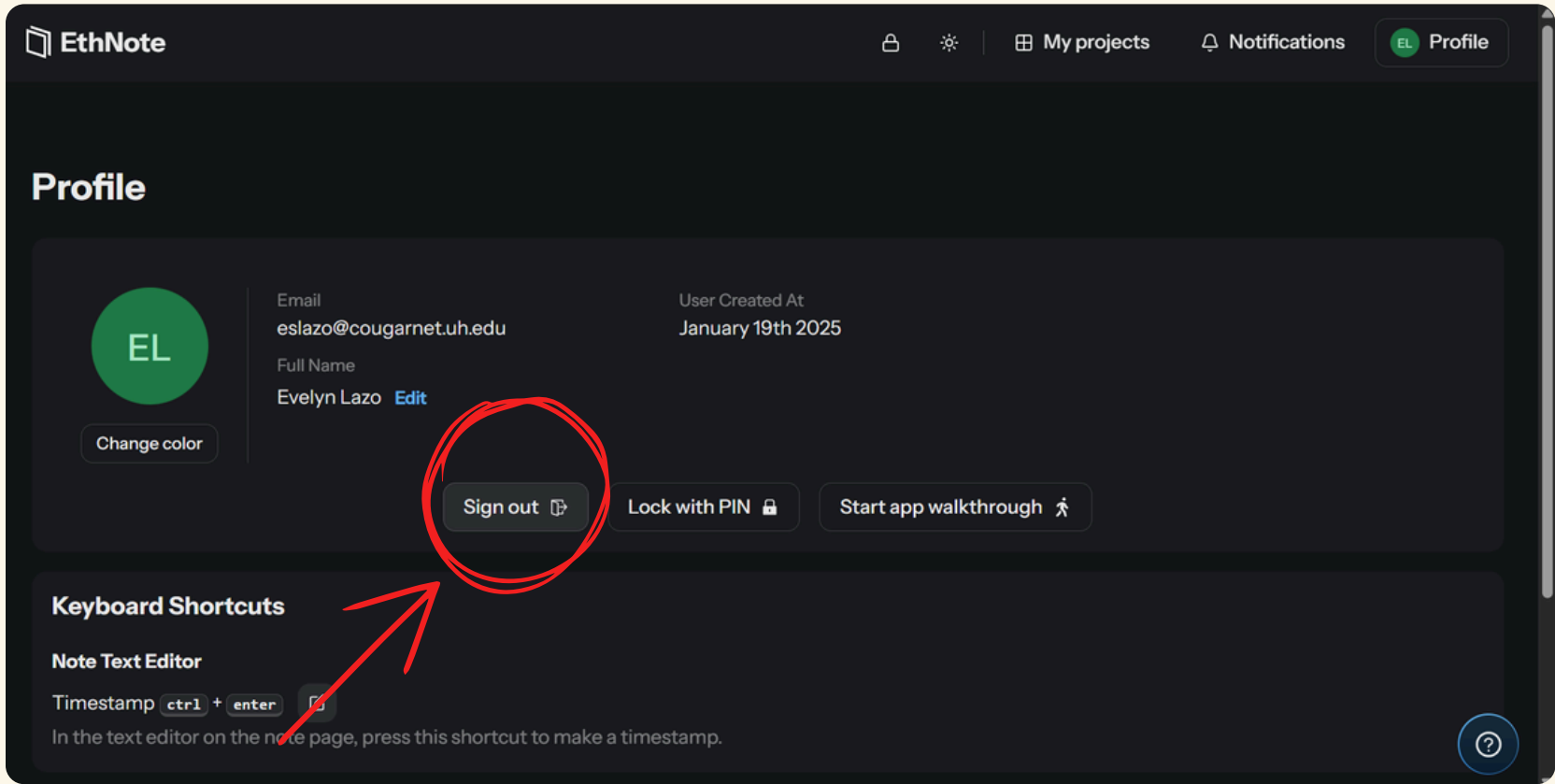
1. Enter project “Folkemødet”
2. Select one of the “Main Stage” files from the notes list by clicking on the selection box
3. Scroll back up and click on “Download Selected” box
4. Name the file anything, leave everything as is (single file, .txt) and download
5. Enter a new project
6. Click on “import notes” next to the “new notes” box
7. Upload that downloaded file

## Overall Findings:

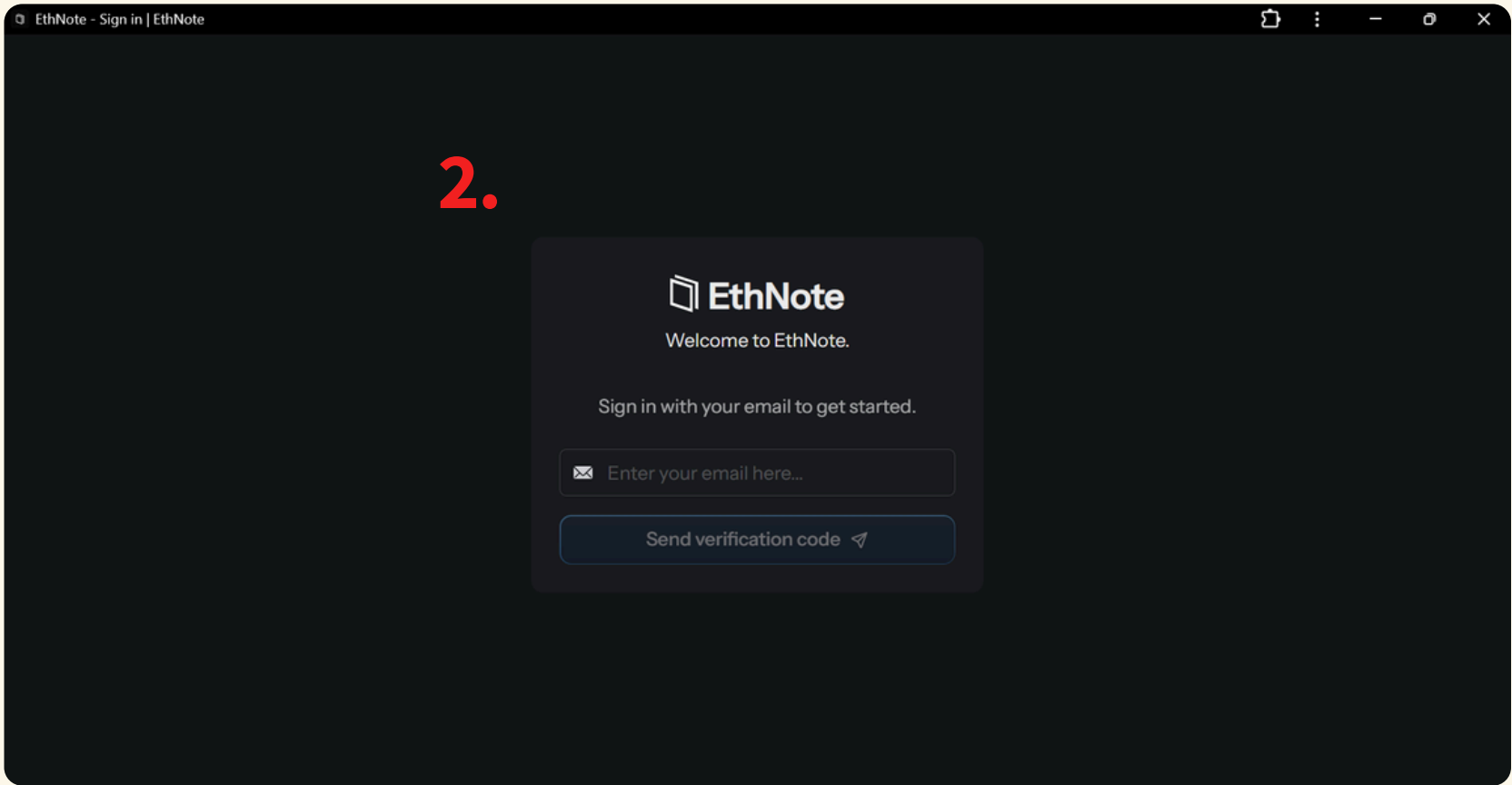
- Users were **able to find the note, but struggled** with understanding the **next steps to move or upload it**.
- **Import Notes option caused confusion**, as users expected a way to move an existing note, not upload a new file.
- **Navigation and icon placement** were **not intuitive** for completing the task without assistance.
- **First-time users found the process difficult**, although they believed it might be easier with more experience.
- Task **completion times varied**, with some users needing guidance after 2 minutes, and others completing it after initial struggles (~53 seconds).

# TASK #7:

Sign out of your account and log back in.



1.



2.



# TASK #7:

Sign out of your account and log back in.

## Solution:

1. Go to My projects page
2. Click profile in the top right
3. Click sign out
4. Click Login at the top of the page
5. Type your email
6. Put in the verification code sent to that email
7. Click log in

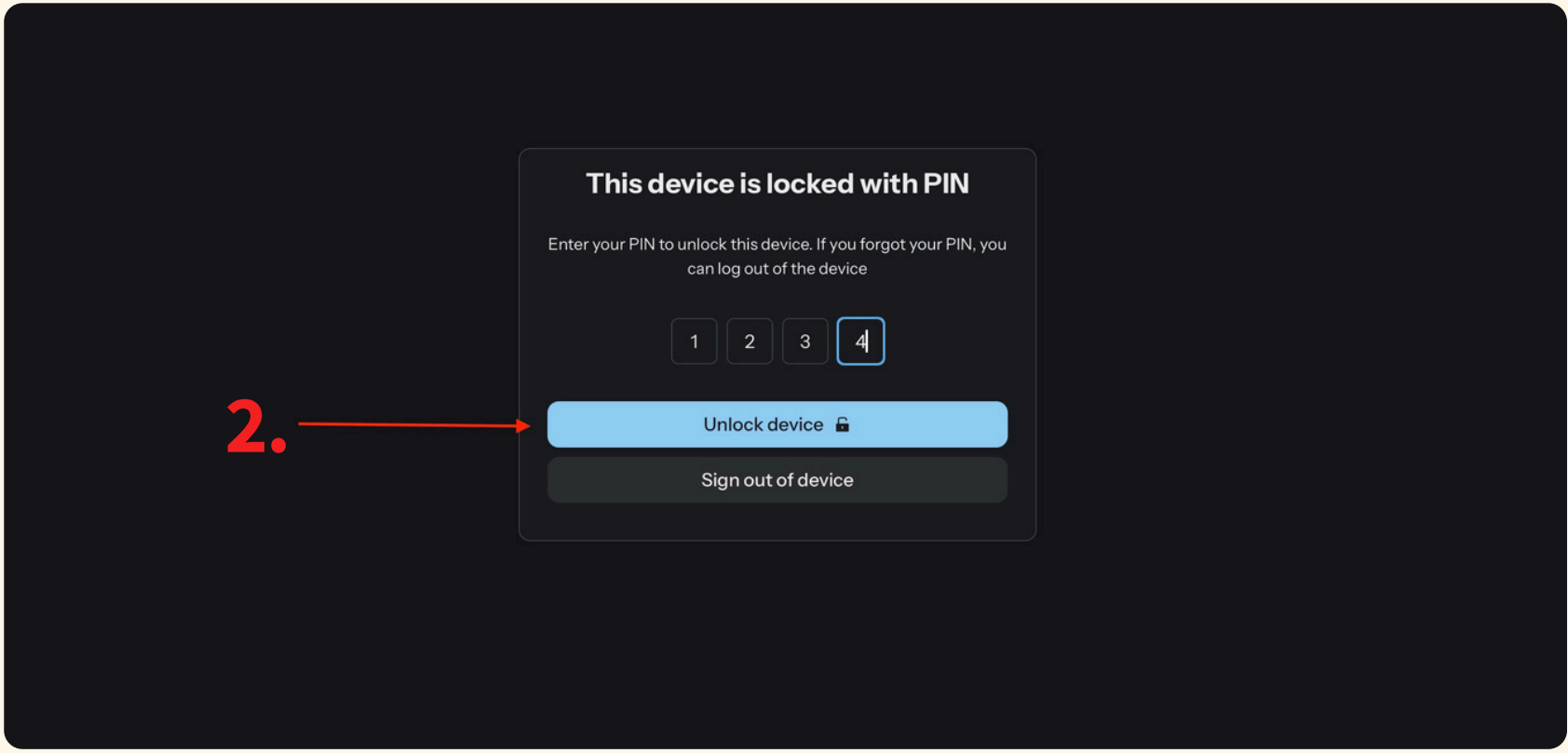
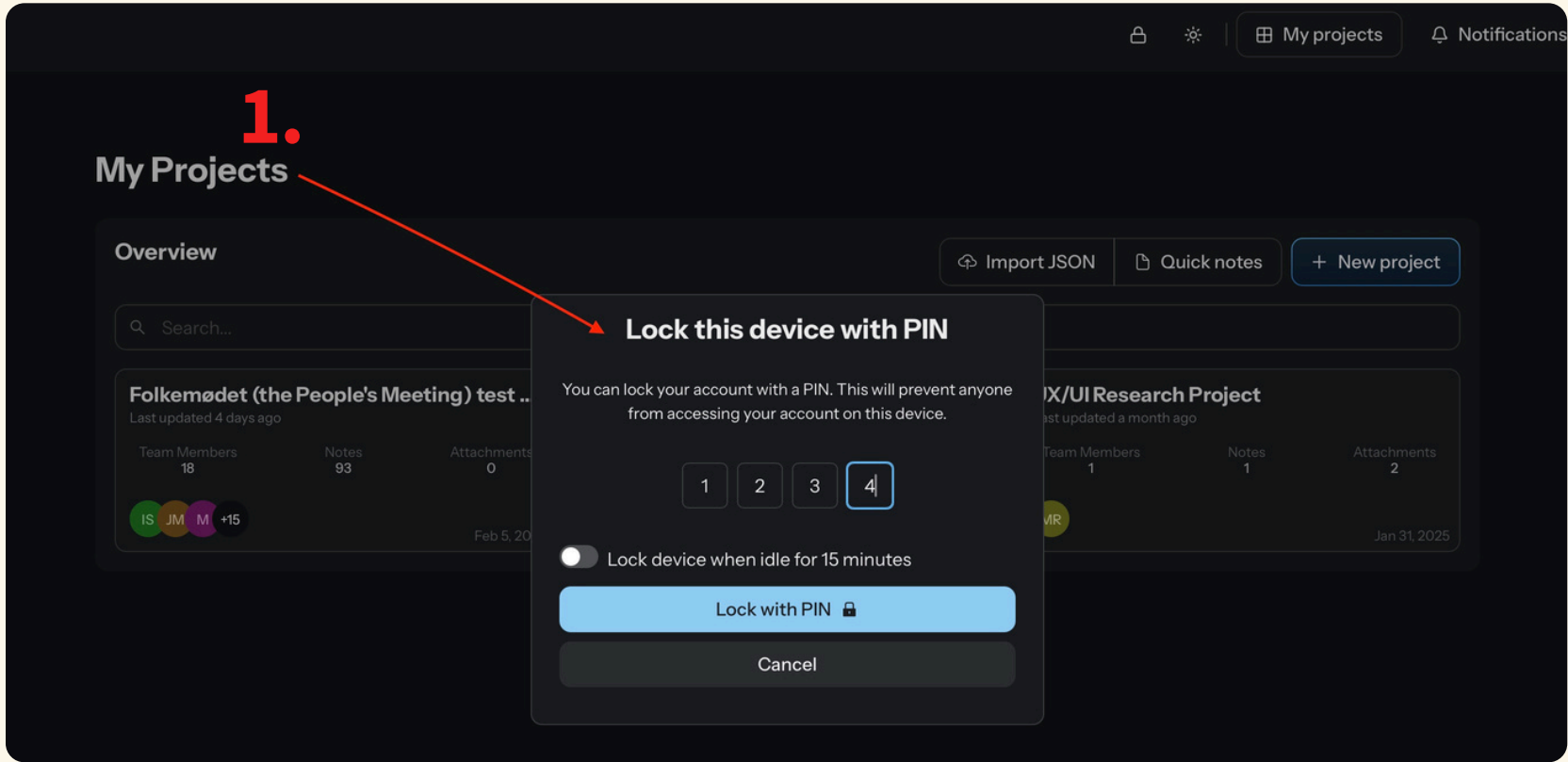
## Overall Findings:

- **Some** testers had **trouble locating** the **logout** option, as **“My Profile”** in the top right **wasn’t immediately noticeable**.
- Despite this, they were able to log out and log back in without major issues.
- **Login codes** were sent **promptly**, and the process was **quick**.
- **Once understood, navigation felt intuitive and aligned with user expectations**.
- **Most** testers rated the experience **7 out of 7**, noting everything was clearly labeled and easy to follow.
- Overall, the task was **completed efficiently**, with **minimal delays**.



# TASK #8:

Lock your account with the PIN “1234”.



# TASK #8:

Lock your account with the PIN “1234”.

## Solution:

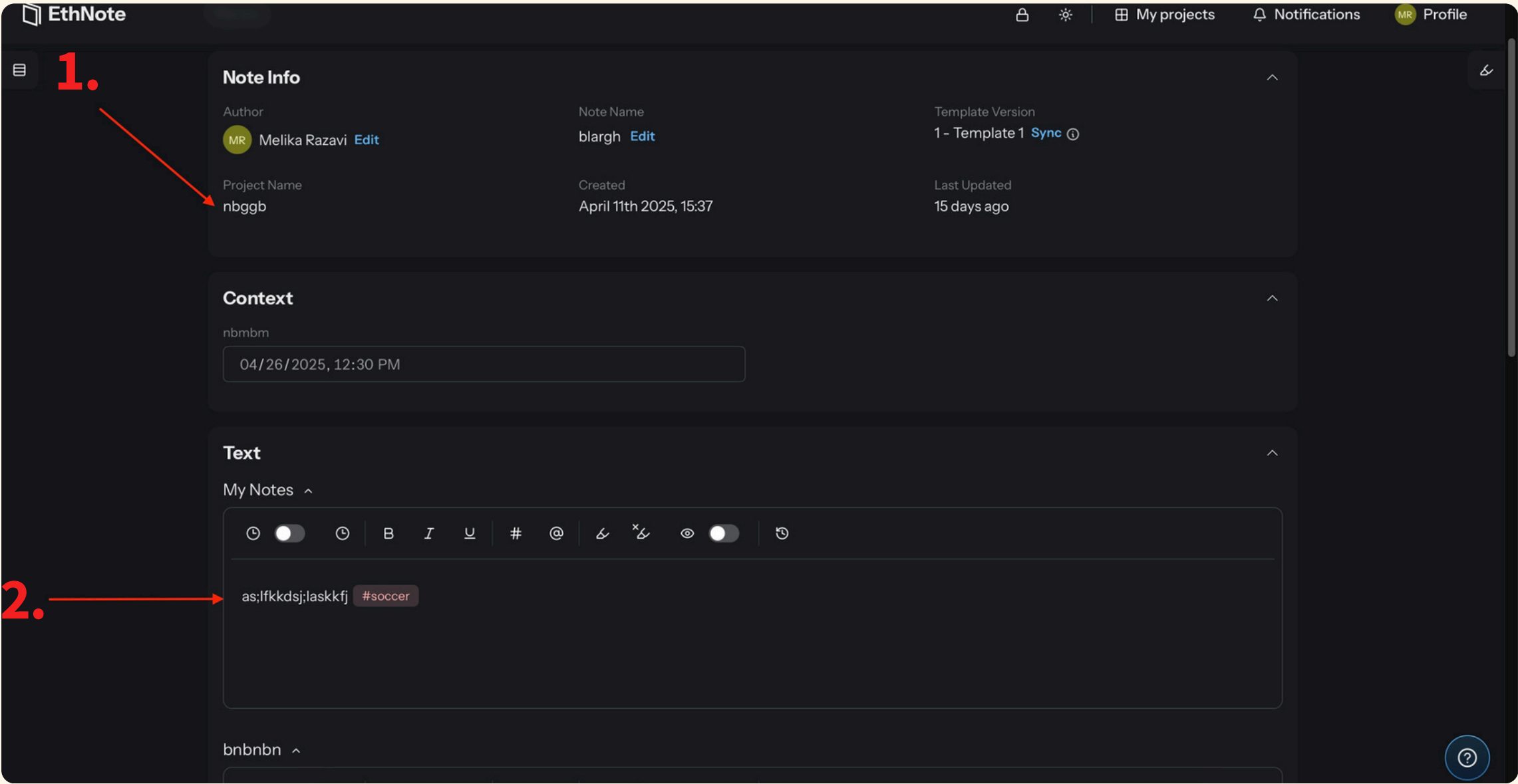
1. Go to My projects page
2. Click the lock icon in the nav bar
3. Add code
4. Click lock with pin
5. Click Sign-out of device

## Overall Findings:

- Users were able to **locate** the "**Lock with PIN**" **feature** relatively **quickly** without major issues.
- Finding the "**Sign-out Device**" **option** took noticeably **longer**, causing some **hesitation and confusion**.
- After some searching, users were eventually able to locate the "Sign-out Device" successfully.
- Overall, users **encountered minor navigation difficulties**, particularly with **features** that were **less prominently placed**.

# TASK #9:

Click on any note, and add a couple of hashtags to it.



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Click on any note, and add a couple of hashtags to it.

## Solution:

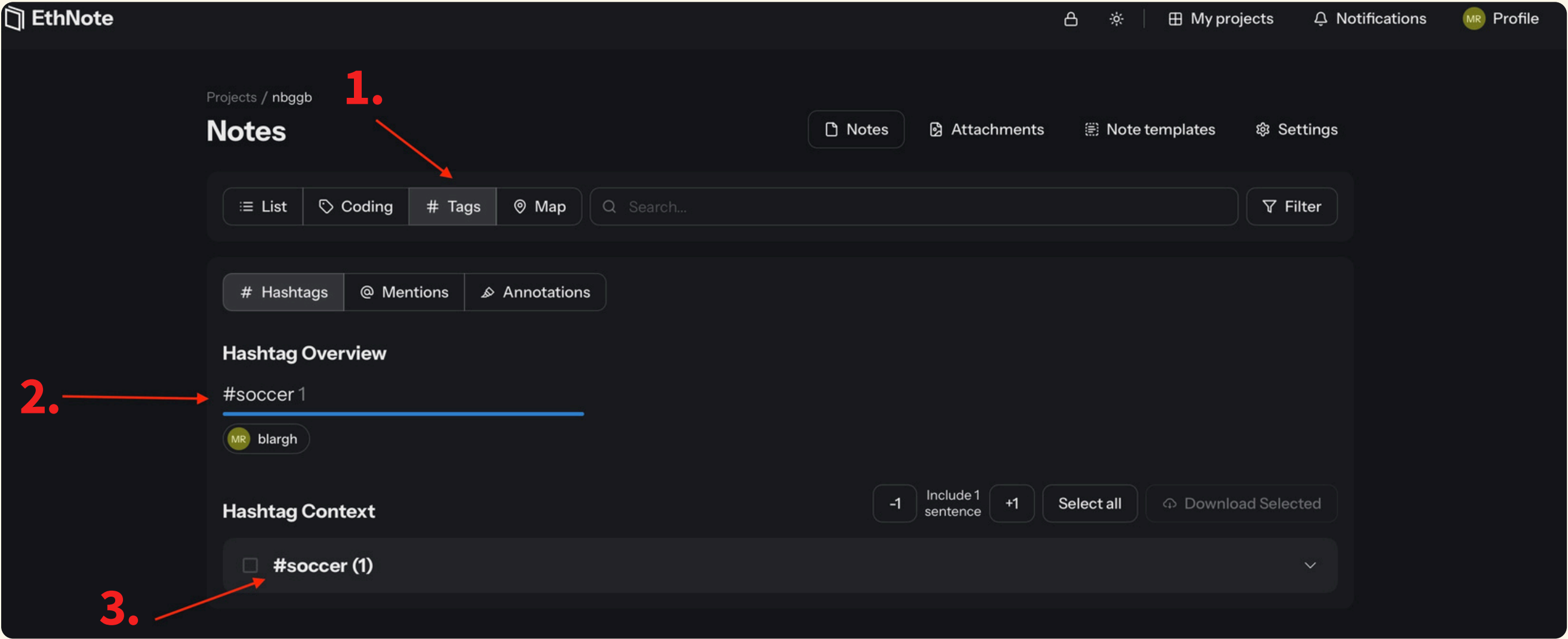
1. Click on a note to open it.
2. Scroll down to Text and click the # button or type # and a word.

## Overall Findings:

- Users were **able to access and open a note quickly** without any noticeable confusion.
- **Adding hashtags** (either by clicking the "#" button or typing "Soccer"#S) was **straightforward** and **intuitive for most** users.
- Overall, users **completed** the task with **little to no difficulty**, demonstrating that the **feature** was **easily accessible and user-friendly**.

# TASK #10:

Where would you go to see a list of all your hashtags for this project?





# TASK #10:

Where would you go to see a list of all your hashtags for this project?

## Solution:

1. Go back to the project's main page (they will have to get out of the individual note)
2. Click on the Tags button.
3. (Bonus: you can then ask them to return to the project's main page. They will have to click the List button to do that.)

## Overall Findings:

- Users initially **needed a moment to realize** they had to **exit the individual note** and **return to the main project** page.
- Once on the main page, **most** users **located the "Tags" button without major difficulty**, though some hesitated briefly.
- **A few users needed extra guidance** to understand that they had to use the "List" button to fully return to the project's main view after checking tags.
- Overall, the task was completed successfully, but there was **minor confusion during navigation between individual notes and the main project page**.

# SEQ Scores

## Single Ease Question

A simple, single-question usability metric that asks users to rate how easy or difficult they found a task.

The SEQ scores helped us measure how easy or difficult each task was for users on a **7-point scale (1 = very difficult, 7 = very easy)**. Across tasks, we observed inconsistent ratings, reflecting variability in user experience depending on the feature being tested.

**High scores (6–7)** were seen in tasks like **logging in/out** and **adding hashtags**, indicating those features were more intuitive.

**Low scores (1–3)** appeared in tasks involving **walkthroughs, note management, and importing content**, suggesting users faced confusing navigation, unfamiliar icons, or unclear workflows.

These scores highlighted specific pain points in the interface and helped us identify which areas need immediate attention to improve overall usability and reduce user frustration.

# SEQ Scores

|          | Tester 1 | Tester 2 | Tester 3 | Tester 4 | Tester 5 | Tester 6 | Tester 7 |
|----------|----------|----------|----------|----------|----------|----------|----------|
| Task 1:  | 2        | 1        | 6        | 2        | 6        | 1        | 2        |
| Task 2:  | 6        | 3        | 5        | 6        | 1        | 7        | 1        |
| Task 3:  | 6        | 5        | 4        | 1        | 3        | 4        | 7        |
| Task 4:  | 6        | 2        | 7        | 1        | 7        | 4        | 6        |
| Task 5:  | 5        | 5        | 4        | 5        | 6        | 4        | 7        |
| Task 6:  | 6        | 2        | 2        | 4        | 1        | 6        | 2        |
| Task 7:  | 5        | 7        | 7        | 7        | 6        | 6        | 7        |
| Task 8:  | 7        | 7        | 7        | 7        | 7        | 7        | 7        |
| Task 9:  | 7        | 1        | 5        | 4        | 1        | 7        | 1        |
| Task 10: | 7        | 1        | 7        | 6        | 6        | 3        | 7        |



# SUS SCORES

## System Usability Scale

A numerical representation of a user's perception of a product's usability, ranging from 0 to 100.

|        |    |    |    |      |    |      |    |
|--------|----|----|----|------|----|------|----|
| Scores | 75 | 80 | 30 | 22.5 | 40 | 52.5 | 40 |
|--------|----|----|----|------|----|------|----|

### Individual Scores:

The **wide range of scores reflects an inconsistent user experience**, with some users navigating the app more easily than others—highlighting the **need for a more intuitive and cohesive design**.

### Average Score: 48.6

This **score falls below the industry average of 68**, indicating that users found the **app difficult to navigate and less intuitive** than expected. Key areas for improvement include **clearer navigation, more intuitive labeling, and better visibility of core features**.

# Overall Findings

Key problems included unclear navigation paths, confusing layout, poor annotation visibility, unclear icons and labels, inconsistent back button behavior, and varying task performance, all indicating areas needing improvement.

## Usability Issues Identified

- **Unclear navigation paths:** Features like the walkthrough, annotation tools, and note transfers were hard to find without guidance.
- **Confusing layout:** Many users struggled with locating or completing tasks due to unintuitive menu placements (e.g., walkthrough in Profile, Delete under Settings).
- **Annotation visibility:** Users couldn't always see where their annotations appeared, causing confusion.
- **Redundant icons and unclear labels:** Some icons lacked clarity, making it difficult to know what certain buttons did.
- **Back button behavior:** Navigation between notes and project views caused minor confusion.
- **Task performance varied:** Tasks like searching for notes or importing files ranged from quick success to needing direct assistance.

# Overall Findings

The usability study revealed a generally smooth login/logout experience, clear hashtag functionality, and understandable basic navigation after some user familiarization.

However, the average SUS score of 48.6 and inconsistent SEQ ratings highlighted significant usability issues.

## Strengths

- **Finding 1:** Easy login/logout process: Most testers found the login experience smooth, fast, and intuitive.
- **Finding 2:** Hashtag functionality was clear: Users had little to no trouble adding hashtags to notes.
- **Finding 3:** Basic navigation was understandable: Once familiar with the interface, users completed tasks more efficiently.

## Quantitative Insights

- **Finding 1:** Average SUS Score - 48.6 (below industry average, indicating room for improvement)
- **Finding 2:** SEQ Ratings - Varied widely between testers, showing inconsistent user experience across tasks.

# Thank you!

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We truly appreciate the opportunity to test Ethnote's usability and contribute to its improvement.

Jane Nguyen, Sergio Gutierrez, Sandra Tran, Carisia Ramirez, Melika Razavi, Mary Gomez, Evelyn Lazo, Jose Martinez, Yaridka Turrubiarres, Isabelle Stuba

